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EE/RPF

For use from May/November 2027

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Student personal code:

Extended essay - Reflection and progress form

Student: *This form is to be completed by you and your supervisor during the progress and completion of the extended essay. It records your progress through the extended essay process and includes your reflective statement addressing your extended essay experience. You must undertake three formal reflection sessions with your supervisor: The first formal reflection session should focus on your initial ideas and how you plan to undertake your research; the interim reflection session takes place once a significant amount of your research has been completed, and the final session will be in the form of a viva voce, once you have completed and handed in your extended essay. This document acts as a record in supporting the authenticity of your work. Following the viva voce, you write a* ***reflective statement*** *of no more than 500 words., which must be included on the RPF.*

The completion of this form is a mandatory requirement of the extended essay. It must be submitted together with the completed essay. The reflective statement will then be assessed under Criterion E. Students and supervisors should be aware that a mark of 0 will be awarded by the examiner for criterion E if the RPF is blank or the reflective statement is written in a language other than that of the accompanying essay.

Supervisor: *You must have three reflection sessions with each student, one early in the process, an interim meeting and then the final viva voce. Other check-in sessions are permitted but do not need to be recorded on this sheet. After each reflection session you must record the month that the reflection session took place, the student's year of DP study at that time and initial the form.*
By submitting this student work for assessment, you are taking responsibility for its authenticity. No piece of student work should be uploaded/submitted to the e-Coursework system if its authenticity is in doubt.

First reflection session

Month: DP year (1 or 2): Supervisor initials:

Interim reflection session

Month: DP year (1 or 2): Supervisor initials:

Final reflection session – Viva voce

Month: DP year (1 or 2): Supervisor initials:

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Reflective statement

(No more than 500 words, written in the same language as the accompanying extended essay)

As a child, I frequently visited my grandfather's store in the Mumbai Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC) and saw the Mathadi workers unloading all the jute bags from the farmers. I saw the workers go on strike for better wages and working conditions. I was curious whether the board and union behind their actions truly benefitted the workers, as they often impeded economic activity, leading to fewer employment opportunities. So I decided to pursue my Extended Essay in economics to study the labour market conditions of these Mathadi workers. I hoped to learn more about how economics guides us to the levers we can use to drive societal progress. My goal was to investigate the impact of the labour board and unions on the wages and well-being of the workers.

I started by reading the literature I obtained from governmental sources and journal articles on the history of the Mathadi workers. From my research into the relevant economic theory, I've learned how a labour board and union can transform a labour market. This created the opportunity for me to identify a causal impact. However, a significant proportion of the secondary literature originates from the union or board, or researchers affiliated with them. While these sources provided me with in-depth information about the increased representation of the Mathadi workers, they seem to neglect the impact on employment opportunities and suggest that the changes in the marked have only benefitted the workers.

Despite researching intensively, I could not find literature that considered the perspectives of all stakeholder, including those that may be worse off because of the union and board, such as employers. Therefore, I decided to directly engage with stakeholders, specifically the workers and employers, through primary research. Realising that they might be uncomfortable sharing sensitive information and fear criticizing the politically-connected union, I feared they might answer dishonestly. I tried to overcome this problem by ensuring confidentiality and strategically framing the questions.

Through my research, I concluded that the labour market evolved through three stages, each corresponding to a different economic theory. My research led me to conclude that the impact of the union and board has changed over time. At first they immensely benefitted workers; however, today, they have become analogous to monopolists. Therefore, fewer Mathadi workers are hired compared to a counterfactual world, but they have better wages and well-being. I have grown as a learner because since this theory was not on the economics course, I had to research independently.

In addition to deepening my understanding of economics, writing the Extended essay has made me a better researcher, writer and communicator. I realized the importance of combining theory with reality by engaging with stakeholders and data. I have learned to think critically and convey my feelings. I thoroughly enjoyed analyzing solutions to a problem I care about deeply. While I faced challenges, especially since I had never participated in field research, my supervisor’s guidance allowed me to overcome these problems and complete my study. (497 words)

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